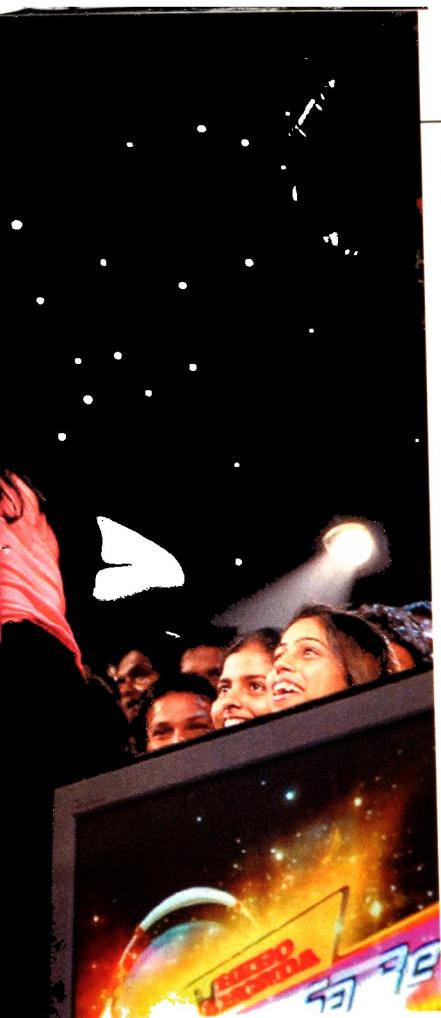




Average TRPs for June 2007

Sa Re Ga Ma Pa Challenge 2007: 4.14

Star Voice of India: 3.64

Indian Idol 3: 3.18

Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi: 6.66

Kahani Ghar Ghar Kii: 6.05

Kasautii Zindagii Kay: 3.92



CHEESY CHALLENGE: A blushing Aditya Narayan being kissed by a girl from the audience (left); Aadesh Shrivastav, Jatin and Alka Yagnik on Voice of India

Sony's *Indian Idol 3*, declare their love for guest judges (Aneek Dhar to Dia Mirza in *Sa Re Ga Ma Pa Challenge 2007*) and when all else fails, oblige by behaving like overworked soap stars and fainting on the sets (like Sarika Singh who did so out of disappointment and fatigue, again on *Sa Re Ga Ma Pa*, where two episodes are usually compressed into a day's shoot, which starts at 7 a.m. and can go on till 4 a.m. the next day). All these incidents, complete with photographs and numbers of all participants (who invariably offer comments even more incendiary than on the show), are duly circulated by efficient publicists. The blogs are instant and insightful in their analyses while YouTube is flooded with cheesy clips. Everything needs to be underlined, admits Gajendra Singh, who did it in bold highlighter for 14 years on *Sa Re Ga Ma Pa* and is now purveying his art of manufacture on Star Plus's *Voice of India*.

In this atmosphere of full-on public performances, no one is safe. Not even the venerable Asha Bhosle, or the revered Khayyam. Whether it is the dramatic Himesh Reshammiya or the scarily hairy Darbar, no one wants to be upstaged. The bigger the object of your attrition, the noisier the headlines—Reshammiya takes on Ashatai after she disses him by rolling her eyes whenever he sings, while Darbar takes *panga* with Khayyam over contestant

Jyoti Mishra singing out of tune. Each dispute is then billed as the ultimate *mahayuddh/agnipariksha/sankat* and is accompanied by black and white freeze frames. Where conflict doesn't work, gimmicks are enough—Yagnik turns up at an audition in a burka, while Chang and Deepali are shown as falling in love on *Indian Idol 3*. And superlatives are flaunted mindlessly: Jyoti is *Sholay's* Basanti for Darbar, while Sumedha Karmahe is India's Britney Spears for Lahiri. For one startled contestant in *Voice of India*, Abhijeet is motivated to flail his arms and feet about and say he sang better than the original.

In a culture of babble, bad manners have become the byword for reality tv bluebloods—not surprising that professional rude head Ravi Kissen has been made judge on *Bathroom Singer*. As Dadlani puts it, rather strongly, "It's all crap, over-dramatised, manipulated, and designed to sensationalise." It's also the first and the last time he says he and his musical partner Shekhar Ravijiani will appear on *Sa Re Ga Ma Pa*. Everything is for effect, he points out. "Every time we say something like the singers are the real stars, we are edited out." Instead, what is highlighted is their unhappiness when they are made to wait for two hours, while Reshammiya turns up late for the shoot. His explanation: "*Star ke liye toh wait karna hi padta hai...*" is duly